

LOVELY PROFESSIONAL UNIVERSITY

SCHOOL OF LAW



CA – 01 HISTORY (HIS120)

BACKWARD CASTE MOVEMENT

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INTRODUCTION

- **The backward caste movement is one of the most important social and political movements in modern Indian history. It refers to the long struggle of the 'backward classes' — a broad group of castes placed below the upper castes (mainly Brahmins) but above the 'untouchable' castes in the traditional caste hierarchy — to gain social respect, education, economic opportunity and political power.**
- **For centuries, Indian society was organized around the caste system, which decided a person's occupation, social status and access to education purely by birth. The upper castes, especially Brahmins, enjoyed control over religion, learning, administration and land. The intermediate and lower castes, who form the numerical majority of India's population, were denied these opportunities. The backward caste movement grew out of the desire of these communities to break this pattern of exclusion.**
- **This assignment traces the origin, growth and impact of the backward caste movement — from its early beginnings in the nineteenth century to its present-day form as a major force in Indian politics and society. It looks at the leaders who shaped the movement, the organizations they built, the laws and policies that resulted from their efforts, and the lasting significance of the movement for Indian democracy.**
- **It is important to distinguish the backward caste movement from the Dalit movement, even though the two are closely related and often overlapped in practice. The backward caste (OBC) movement generally represents intermediate, 'Shudra' or peasant-artisan castes who, while socially and educationally disadvantaged compared to the upper castes, were not treated as 'untouchable'. The Dalit movement, most closely associated with Dr B.R. Ambedkar, represents castes that were historically placed outside the caste system altogether and subjected to untouchability. Both movements fought Brahminical dominance and often worked together, but their specific histories, leaders and constitutional categories (OBC versus SC) are distinct, and this assignment focuses mainly on the former while noting points of overlap.**

Historical Background and Context

To understand the backward caste movement, it is necessary to understand the caste system itself. Traditional Hindu society was divided into four varnas — Brahmins (priests and scholars), Kshatriyas (rulers and warriors), Vaishyas (traders and farmers) and Shudras (laborers and service providers) — with a further group considered 'outside' the varna system altogether (later called Dalits or Scheduled Castes). In practice, society was divided into thousands of local jatis (sub-castes), most of which fell under the broad category of Shudras. It is largely from this Shudra and intermediate-caste base that the 'backward classes' emerged.

2.1 Colonial Rule and New Opportunities

British colonial rule, whatever its faults, introduced modern education, printing, censuses and a new administrative system. These created new opportunities and new grievances. Census operations from 1881 onwards required people to record their caste, which made caste identity more rigid but also more visible — and organizable. Modern education, though limited, allowed a small number of people from intermediate castes to become teachers, lawyers and journalists, and they began to question the domination of Brahmins in government jobs, colleges and cultural life.

2.2 Meaning of the Term 'Backward Classes'

The word 'backward' in this context does not mean lack of intelligence or ability. It is a technical, constitutional term describing communities that were 'socially and educationally backward' because of centuries of caste-based restrictions on their access to education, temples, public wells, and respectable occupations. In the Constitution and in everyday administration, India today recognizes three broad backward categories: Scheduled Castes (SCs, formerly called 'untouchables' or Depressed Classes), Scheduled Tribes (STs), and Other Backward Classes (OBCs) — the last of these being the main subject of the 'backward caste movement' as commonly understood, since SCs and STs have their own separate (though related) history of struggle led substantially by Dr B.R. Ambedkar.

It is useful to remember that OBCs are not a single caste but an administrative category covering thousands of separate jatis — from prosperous farming castes to poor artisan and service castes — who are grouped together mainly because they fall between the

'forward' castes and the SC/ST communities in the traditional hierarchy, and because each faces some degree of social and educational disadvantage.

2.3 Regional Roots of the Movement

- The movement did not begin as a single, unified campaign. It grew separately in different regions, shaped by local conditions:
- In Maharashtra, Jyotirao Phule attacked the ideology of Brahmin superiority and started schools for girls and lower castes as early as the 1840s and 1850s.
- In princely Kolhapur, Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj used his position as ruler to introduce reservation in government jobs for backward communities.
- In Kerala, the Ezhava community, guided by Narayana Guru, organized the SNDP Yogam to fight for temple entry and social dignity.
- In Madras Presidency (Tamil Nadu), non-Brahmin castes organized against the near-monopoly of Brahmins in administration and education, leading to the Justice Party and later the Self-Respect Movement.

These regional movements shared a common thread: they saw Brahminical dominance — in religion, administration and education — as the main obstacle to the progress of the majority of Indians, and they sought remedies through education, self-organization and, eventually, state policy.

2.4 Why the Movement Grew Strongest in the South

The backward caste movement was especially strong and early in South India for a specific historical reason: in provinces like Madras, Brahmins formed a very small percentage of the population (often quoted as around 3%) but held a very large share — sometimes over half — of government jobs, college seats and legal positions. This visible gap between population share and share of opportunities gave the non-Brahmin movement a clear, measurable grievance around which to organize, well before similar movements matured in North India.

Major Developments and Key Events

The backward caste movement unfolded over almost one hundred and fifty years, moving from social reform to political organization to constitutional policy. The timeline below shows its major milestones.

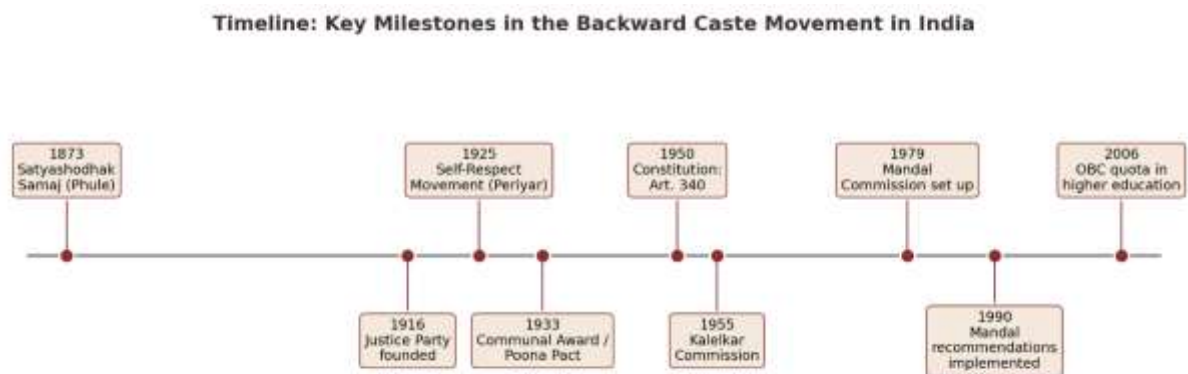


Figure 1: Timeline of key milestones in the backward caste movement in India.

3.1 The Early Reform Phase (1870s–1910s)

Jyotirao Phule founded the Satyashodhak Samaj (Truth-Seekers' Society) in 1873 in Pune. It aimed to free Shudras and 'untouchables' from the domination of Brahmin priests and to spread education among them. This is generally regarded as the starting point of organized backward-caste assertion in India.

3.2 The Non-Brahmin Movement and the Justice Party (1910s–1920s)

In Madras Presidency, non-Brahmin leaders felt that Brahmins, though a small percentage of the population, held a disproportionate share of government jobs and college seats. In 1916 they formed the South Indian Liberal Federation, popularly called the Justice Party, to demand proportional representation for non-Brahmins in public life. The Justice Party later formed governments in Madras and pushed through some of India's earliest caste-based reservation orders (such as the Communal Government Order of 1921).

3.3 The Self-Respect Movement (from 1925)

E.V. Ramasamy, popularly known as Periyar, launched the Self-Respect Movement in 1925 in Tamil Nadu. It went further than the Justice Party by directly attacking the

caste system, religious orthodoxy, and Brahmin priesthood, and by promoting rationalism, women's rights, and inter-caste marriage. The Self-Respect Movement later evolved into the Dravidar Kazhagam (1944) and, after a split, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in 1949 — parties that continue to shape Tamil Nadu politics today.

3.4 Constitutional Recognition (1930s–1950s)

The colonial government's Communal Award of 1932 and the subsequent Poona Pact (1932) recognised the need for special safeguards for depressed classes. After Independence, the Constitution of India (1950) included Article 340, which empowered the President to appoint a commission to investigate the conditions of 'socially and educationally backward classes' and recommend steps for their advancement.

3.5 Backward Classes Commissions and the Mandal Report (1953–1990)

The Kalelkar Commission (1953) was India's first Backward Classes Commission, but its report was not fully implemented. The Second Backward Classes Commission, headed by B.P. Mandal, was set up in 1979 and submitted its report in 1980, identifying about 3,743 castes as 'Other Backward Classes' (OBCs) and recommending 27% reservation for them in central government jobs. The recommendations were implemented in 1990, sparking large-scale protests as well as strong support, and permanently changing the shape of Indian politics.

3.6 The Post-Mandal Era (1990s–present)

Since the 1990s, backward caste identity has become a central axis of Indian politics, giving rise to powerful regional parties, expanding reservation to higher education (2006) and, more recently, to demands by groups such as the Marathas, Patels, Jats and Gujjars for inclusion in the OBC category. This period also saw the rise of demands for a nationwide caste census, sub-categorization of OBCs (to ensure that the most backward among them are not overshadowed by relatively better-off OBC castes), and continued litigation over the limits of reservation.

3.7 A Snapshot of Regional Movements

The table below summarizes how the movement developed differently across regions.

Region	Organisation / Movement	Focus
Maharashtra	Satyashodhak Samaj (1873)	Anti-Brahmin reform, education for Shudras and women, dignity of labour.
Kolhapur (princely state)	State reservation policy (1902)	50% reservation in state services for backward communities — an early administrative model.
Kerala	SNDP Yogam (1903), Vaikom Satyagraha (1924–25)	Social reform among Ezhavas, temple entry, removal of untouchability.
Madras Presidency	Justice Party (1916)	Proportional representation for non-Brahmins in jobs and legislature.
Tamil Nadu	Self-Respect Movement (1925), DK (1944), DMK (1949)	Anti-caste rationalism, Dravidian identity, mass politics.
Bihar / North India	Backward classes politics after Mandal (1990)	OBC political assertion, farmer-caste mobilization, coalition politics.

Important Personalities and Their Contributions

Several individuals gave direction, ideology and leadership to the backward caste movement across different regions and periods. The table below summarizes the key figures.

Personality	Region	Key Contribution
Jyotirao Phule (1827–1890)	Maharashtra	Founded Satyashodhak Samaj (1873); opposed Brahmin dominance; promoted education for Shudras, Dalits and women; wrote 'Gulamgiri' (Slavery).
Shahu Maharaj (1874–1922)	Kolhapur	Ruler who introduced 50% reservation for backward classes in state services in 1902 — among the earliest reservation policies in India.
Narayana Guru (1856–1928)	Kerala	Spiritual leader of the Ezhava community; guided the SNDP movement; propagated 'One Caste, One Religion, One God for Mankind'.
E.V. Ramasamy 'Periyar' (1879–1973)	Tamil Nadu	Founded the Self-Respect Movement (1925); led the Justice Party tradition; campaigned against Brahminical dominance and for rationalism and social equality.
Dr. B.R. Ambedkar (1891–1956)	Pan-India	Chief architect of the Constitution; championed reservations, abolition of untouchability, and political representation for depressed classes.

Personality	Region	Key Contribution
B.P. Mandal (1918–1982)	Bihar	Chaired the Second Backward Classes Commission (1979) whose report (1980) recommended 27% reservation for OBCs.
Savitribai Phule (1831–1897)	Maharashtra	India's first woman teacher; co-founded girls' schools with Jyotirao Phule; pioneer of women's and backward-caste education.
C.N. Annadurai (1909–1969)	Tamil Nadu	Founded the DMK in 1949, carrying the Self-Respect Movement's ideals into parliamentary politics; became Tamil Nadu's first non-Congress Chief Minister.



JYOTIBA PHULE



Dr. BHIMRAO AMBEDKAR



E.V. RAMASAMY

4.1 Three Leading Figures

Jyotirao Phule is often called the 'father' of the backward caste movement in India. Born into the Mali (gardener) caste, he was deeply influenced by the ideals of liberty and equality and by his own experience of caste discrimination. In 1848, he and his wife Savitribai opened one of India's first schools for girls; he later opened schools for lower-caste children as well. His book 'Gulamgiri' (Slavery), published in 1873, compared the condition of Shudras and 'untouchables' in India to that of enslaved people in America, and argued that Brahminical religious texts had been used to justify their subjugation.

Periyar E.V. Ramasamy began his public life as a Congress worker but resigned in the early 1920s, disillusioned by the party's unwillingness to fight caste discrimination within its own ranks and by an incident where Dalit students were denied food at a Congress-run feeding programme unless served separately. He went on to build the Self-Respect Movement into a mass movement that questioned not only caste but also religious superstition, arguing that true self-respect for non-Brahmins required freedom from ritual, myth and priestly control.

Dr B.R. Ambedkar, though most closely associated with the Dalit (Scheduled Caste) movement, shaped the entire backward-caste struggle. As chairman of the Constitution's Drafting Committee, he ensured that Articles 15, 16 and 340 gave legal and constitutional backing to affirmative action for backward classes, not only for his own community. His broader critique of the caste system, expressed in works like 'Annihilation of Caste' (1936), continues to influence backward-caste as well as Dalit politics.

Political and Administrative Aspects

The backward caste movement had a profound effect on Indian politics and administration, moving from social protest to formal state policy.

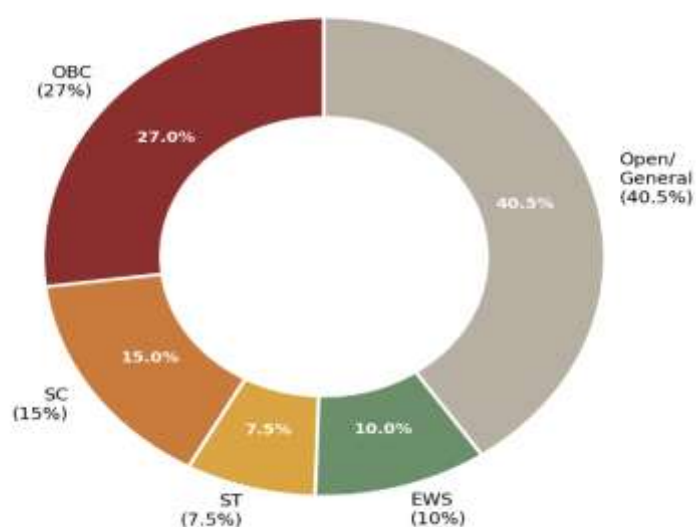
5.1 From Social Movement to Political Party

In South India, backward-caste organizations transformed themselves into political parties (the Justice Party, later the DMK and AIADMK) that have governed Tamil Nadu almost continuously since 1967. In North India, the Mandal-era mobilization gave rise to parties such as the Samajwadi Party, Rashtriya Janata Dal and Janata Dal (United), built around OBC political leadership.

5.2 Reservation Policy

The most significant administrative outcome of the movement is the system of reservation (affirmative action) in government jobs, educational institutions and, since 1993, local self-government bodies (panchayats and municipalities). Following the Mandal Commission's implementation in 1990 and the 2019 addition of a quota for Economically Weaker Sections (EWS), the broad reservation structure in central institutions looks as shown below.

Reservation Structure in Central Govt. Jobs & Higher Education (Post-Mandal Commission, incl. 2019 EWS quota)



Reservation for OBCs in central government jobs was extended to higher education institutions in 2006 through the Central Educational Institutions (Reservation in Admission) Act. Reservation policy remains one of the most debated subjects in Indian politics, with courts periodically reviewing its scope (for example, the Supreme Court's 1992 Indra Sawhney judgment, which upheld 27% OBC reservation but introduced the 'creamy layer' exclusion and capped total reservation at 50%).

5.3 Political Representation

The movement also increased the representation of backward castes in legislatures, cabinets and the bureaucracy. Where earlier upper castes dominated these institutions, backward-caste leaders now hold chief ministerial and ministerial posts across many states, and caste-based coalition politics has become a standard feature of Indian elections.

Social and Socio-Economic Dimensions

At its heart, the backward caste movement has always been about dignity and material opportunity, not merely political power. Caste in India was never simply a religious label; it decided very concrete things — what work a person could do, whether they could enter a temple or draw water from a common well, whom they could marry, and what kind of education, if any, was available to their children. The social and economic dimensions of the movement therefore addressed these every day, lived aspects of inequality.

6.1 Education

Leaders like Phule and Shahu Maharaj saw education as the key to social change and opened schools for children who had traditionally been denied learning. Reservation in educational institutions later carried this forward, allowing millions of students from backward communities to enter schools, colleges and professional courses.

6.2 Occupational Mobility

Traditionally, caste decided occupation — a person was expected to follow the trade of their birth-caste. The movement encouraged communities to move beyond these fixed occupations. For example, the Ezhava community of Kerala, traditionally associated with toddy-tapping, diversified into trade, teaching and other professions during the twentieth century.

6.3 Economic Backwardness and Land

Many backward castes were historically engaged in agriculture as tenants or small landholders rather than as owners of large estates. Movements for land reform and tenancy rights, particularly in Maharashtra and South India, were closely connected to backward-caste assertion, since access to land meant both economic security and social respect.

6.4 Women's Position

Reformers such as Phule (along with his wife, Savitribai Phule) and Periyar placed strong emphasis on women's education and rights, opposing child marriage, the Devadasi system and restrictions on widow remarriage. Savitribai Phule is remembered as one of India's first female teachers and a pioneer of girls' education.

6.5 Urbanization and New Professions

The growth of towns, railways, factories and government offices under colonial rule, and even faster growth after Independence, gave backward-caste families new avenues outside the village-based caste economy. Migration to cities allowed many to enter trade, clerical work, teaching and later, with the spread of reservation, the civil services, medicine, engineering and law — professions that had earlier been almost entirely closed to them.

Cultural Aspects

- **The movement was not only about jobs and votes; it also challenged the cultural and religious basis of caste hierarchy. Because caste in India was (and to some extent still is) justified through religious texts, myths and rituals, backward-caste leaders realized that legal and political change alone would not be enough — the cultural and religious roots of caste inequality also had to be questioned.**
- **Rejection of Brahminical rituals: The Self-Respect Movement popularized 'Self-Respect Marriages' — simple wedding ceremonies without a Brahmin priest or Sanskrit chants — which were later given legal recognition.**
- **Rationalism and reform of religion: Periyar promoted rationalism and questioned superstition, mythology and the idea of divinely ordained caste hierarchy. Narayana Guru similarly reformed Hindu practice among the Ezhavas, famously installing a Shiva idol at Aruvippuram in defiance of caste restrictions on temple worship.**
- **New literature and press: Backward-caste leaders used newspapers, magazines and pamphlets — such as Periyar's 'Kudi Arasu' and Phule's writings like 'Gulamgiri' — to spread their ideas and build a shared cultural identity among diverse castes.**
- **Language and regional pride: In Tamil Nadu, the movement fused caste assertion with pride in Dravidian language and culture, shaping a distinct regional identity that still influences Tamil politics and cinema.**
- **Temple entry movements: Campaigns for the right of backward and depressed classes to enter temples, use public wells and walk on public roads (such as the Vaikom Satyagraha of 1924–25 in Kerala) were important cultural as well as social battles.**

Legal Systems and Institutions

- The movement's demands were gradually translated into law and formal institutions:
- **Article 340 of the Constitution:** Empowers the President to appoint a commission to investigate the condition of socially and educationally backward classes.
- **Article 15(4) and 16(4):** Allow the State to make special provisions for the advancement of socially and educationally backward classes, including reservation in education and public employment.
- **National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC):** Set up in 1993 and given constitutional status in 2018 (through the 102nd Constitutional Amendment) to examine requests for inclusion in the central OBC list.
- **Indra Sawhney vs Union of India (1992):** The Supreme Court judgment that upheld 27% OBC reservation in central jobs, introduced the 'creamy layer' concept to exclude the well-off among OBCs, and capped total reservations at 50% (with limited exceptions since).
- **Central Educational Institutions (Reservation in Admission) Act, 2006:** Extended 27% OBC reservation to central higher education institutions.
- **103rd Constitutional Amendment (2019):** Introduced a 10% reservation for Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) among those not covered by existing SC/ST/OBC reservations.

Together, these laws and institutions form the administrative backbone through which the demands of the backward caste movement were converted into lasting public policy.

8.1 The 'Creamy Layer' Principle

One of the most important legal safeguards introduced by the Indra Sawhney judgment is the 'creamy layer' rule. It excludes the relatively well-off and well-educated members of OBC communities (for example, children of high-income parents or senior officials) from reservation benefits, on the reasoning that reservation is meant for those who are genuinely disadvantaged, not for every member of a listed caste regardless of personal

circumstance. This principle continues to be revised periodically by the government based on income limits.

8.2 State-Level Variations

Because 'backward classes' lists and reservation percentages can differ from state to state (within the 50% ceiling set by the Supreme Court, except where special laws provide otherwise), each state also maintains its own State Backward Classes Commission. This has allowed regional movements — such as those of the Marathas in Maharashtra or the Patels in Gujarat — to press their own cases for inclusion in state-level OBC lists, sometimes leading to fresh rounds of protest and litigation.

Impact and Historical Significance

- The backward caste movement has left a deep and lasting mark on Indian society, politics and administration.
- Democratization of politics: It broke the near-monopoly of upper castes over political power and brought numerically large communities into positions of leadership.
- Expansion of access to education and jobs: Reservation policy has enabled millions of students and job-seekers from backward communities to access opportunities previously closed to them.
- Social reform: The movement weakened, though did not fully remove, practices of untouchability and rigid caste hierarchy, and encouraged inter-caste interaction.
- Regional political realignment: It gave rise to strong regional and caste-based parties, changing the nature of coalition politics in India, especially after the 1990s.
- Continuing debates: The movement also raised difficult questions that India is still debating — about the balance between caste-based and economic criteria for reservation, the 'creamy layer' within backward classes, and new demands for OBC status from communities such as the Marathas, Patels, Jats and Gujjars.

9.1 Criticisms and Debates

- Like any major social movement, the backward caste movement has attracted both support and criticism, and a balanced study should note both sides.
- Supporters argue that reservation is a necessary correction for centuries of denied opportunity, and that formal legal equality alone (giving everyone the 'same' rules) does not undo the effects of historic and continuing social discrimination.
- Critics argue that caste-based reservation, if continued indefinitely or extended too widely, may not always reach the most deserving individuals within a

backward caste, and that economic criteria might sometimes be a fairer basis for support.

- There is also an ongoing debate about 'sub-categorization' — whether the OBC category itself should be divided into more and less backward tiers, since some OBC castes are politically and economically far more advanced than others.
- Demands for a nationwide caste census (last conducted comprehensively in 1931) reflect the continuing importance of accurate data in deciding these policy questions.

9.2 Before and After: A Quick Comparison

Aspect	Before the Movement	After the Movement
Government jobs	Dominated by upper castes	Reservation ensures OBC representation
Education	Very limited access for backward castes	Wide access, incl. reserved seats in colleges
Political power	Concentrated in upper-caste elites	Backward castes lead parties & governments
Religious practice	Priest-controlled, restricted temple entry	Greater freedom, reformed practices in many regions

Contribution to the Wider Understanding of Indian History

- Studying the backward caste movement adds an essential dimension to the study of modern Indian history, which is too often told only as a story of the freedom struggle against British rule. A history that only records the political fight against the British, without also recording the social fight against caste oppression at home, gives an incomplete picture of what 'freedom' meant to different sections of Indian society.
- It shows that Indian society was also engaged in an internal struggle for social justice, running parallel to the political struggle for independence.
- It highlights that 'reform' in India was not only led by upper-caste social reformers but also by leaders who emerged from within backward communities themselves.
- It connects social history with constitutional and political history, showing how social movements shape law, and how law in turn reshapes society.
- It helps explain present-day Indian politics, where caste continues to be an important factor in elections, government policy and public debate.
- It broadens our understanding of 'nationalism' in India — showing that alongside the demand for freedom from colonial rule, there was an equally important demand for freedom from social oppression at home.
- For instance, Periyar and several other backward-caste leaders were sometimes critical of the mainstream nationalist movement, arguing that political freedom under upper-caste leadership without social reform would simply replace British rule with upper-caste rule. This is an important reminder that Indian nationalism was not a single, unified idea, but a debate involving multiple visions of what a free India should look like — a debate that becomes visible only when the backward caste movement is studied alongside the freedom struggle.

Conclusion

The backward caste movement began as a set of scattered, regional protests against Brahminical dominance in the nineteenth century and grew, over more than a century, into one of the most powerful forces shaping Indian democracy. Through the efforts of reformers such as Jyotirao Phule, Narayana Guru, Periyar and B.R. Ambedkar, and through policy milestones such as the Mandal Commission and constitutional safeguards, the movement transformed the social and political landscape of India. While debates over reservation, caste identity and social justice continue even today, there is no doubt that the backward caste movement fundamentally advanced the ideals of equality and dignity that lie at the heart of the Indian Constitution.

Glossary of Key Terms

Term	Meaning
Varna	The four-fold classification of traditional Hindu society: Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra.
Jati	A local, endogamous sub-caste group; the everyday unit of caste identity in India.
OBC	Other Backward Classes — the constitutional/administrative category covering backward castes other than SCs and STs.
Reservation	A system of reserving a percentage of seats/posts in education, jobs and legislatures for specified groups.
Creamy layer	The relatively well-off section within OBCs who are excluded from reservation benefits.
Self-Respect Marriage	A simple wedding without a Brahmin priest, promoted by the Self-Respect Movement.
Sanskritisation	The process by which a lower or middle caste adopts upper-caste customs to raise its social status.

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